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RETURN

IOM Returns Report R22: Income Gap Drives Male Returnee Distress

IOM's January 2026 GPS Round 22 data reveals that male returnees disproportionately report insufficient access to income-earning opportunities compared to nine percent of female returnees, indicating gendered economic barriers that deter sustainable reintegration. This income gap undermines the viability of return as a long-term option.

3R: Direct evidence of economic barriers to return; policymakers must prioritize job-matching and income-support programs targeting male returnees to prevent re-displacement.

IOM DTM

IOM Crisis Response Plan 2026: 4.41 Million Returnees, One-Third in Conflict-Affected Areas

The IOM Crisis Response Plan 2026 documents that nearly 4.41 million people have returned to their places of residence, with over one-third (37%, approximately 1.63 million) returning to areas still affected by conflict or with severely degraded services. This raises serious questions about

safety, sustainability of return, and service delivery capacity.

3R: Scale of return is significant but quality of return is at risk; targeted infrastructure and service restoration in conflict-affected areas is prerequisite for sustaining human capital reactivation.

IOM CRISIS RESPONSE

IOM DTM Round 23 Tracking: Latest Returns Data Through May 2026

The IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix Round 23 (data collected January–March 2026, published May 2026) provides the most current snapshot of return movements across Ukraine, including regional profiles that highlight differential return rates and conditions across oblasts. This granular data is essential for targeting return-support interventions.

3R: Provides the operational data backbone for 3R Return strategy; oblast-level differentiation allows precision targeting of diaspora reactivation campaigns and return incentive packages.

IOM DTM

Migration Policy Institute: What Determines Whether Refugees Return

The Migration Policy Institute multimedia analysis examines the multi-factor calculus shaping Ukrainian refugees' intentions to return, covering safety perceptions, economic opportunity, family separation, integration in host countries, and the tension between brain drain and potential brain gain. The analysis underscores that return intention is highly conditional and fragile.

3R: Critical framing document for Return pillar; identifies the specific policy levers—security guarantees, economic opportunity, childcare, housing—that most strongly influence return decisions among diaspora.

MIGRATION POLICY INSTITUTE

RECRUIT

World Bank: Diaspora as Strategic Recruitment Resource for Recovery

A World Bank feature (April 2026) positions Ukrainians abroad as a strategic talent reservoir carrying skills, international experience, and networks urgently needed for reconstruction. The report frames diaspora engagement not merely as return migration but as active recruitment of skilled professionals into recovery roles, including remote and hybrid arrangements.

3R: Directly supports Recruit pillar; provides framework for government and private sector to design diaspora talent pipelines, skills registries, and targeted job-matching platforms for recovery sectors.

WORLD BANK

ILO Reskilling Program: 1,000+ Women and Vulnerable Groups Upskilled for Decent Work

An ILO program documented in March 2026 has directly supported around 1,000 persons (minimum 70% women) to access reskilling and upskilling pathways, addressing the structural gap created by female-dominated displacement and the need to integrate returnees and IDPs into a labor market with 15% unemployment. The program targets decent work access for vulnerable populations.

3R: Concrete Recruit-side intervention; demonstrates scalable model for filling labor market gaps with reskilled returnees and IDPs, particularly women who constitute the majority of displaced population.

ILO

KSE Human Capital Chartbook: 1.7 Million Veterans Create Urgent Reskilling Demand

The KSE Institute 2026 Human Capital Chartbook reveals that Ukraine had 10.7 million workers against 10.2 million pensioners in 2025, with 1.7 million veterans—a 2.4x increase—now entering or re-entering the civilian labor market. This structural demographic pressure makes labor market reform, reskilling infrastructure, and education funding reforms top policy priorities.

3R: Defines the structural recruit challenge: absorbing 1.7M veterans requires dedicated vocational pathways, recognition of military skills, and employer incentives—this is the defining recruitment task of 2026-2027.

KSE INSTITUTE

RETAIN

VoxUkraine: 20-30% Annual Loss of Higher Education Applicants Signals Deep Brain Drain

VoxUkraine reports that former Deputy Minister of Education Mykhailo Vynnytskyi confirmed Ukraine is losing 20-30% of higher education applicants annually since the full-scale invasion, representing a catastrophic hollowing of the future knowledge workforce. The article debates whether this is permanent brain drain or temporary wartime dislocation, with evidence pointing increasingly toward structural loss.

3R: Core Retain signal: losing future graduates is the most damaging long-term human capital threat; requires emergency retention measures including scholarships, safe campuses, online degree pathways, and employer-linked study programs.

VOXUKRAINE

KSE Chartbook: Near-Parity of Workers and Pensioners Signals Systemic Labor Market Crisis

The KSE data showing 10.7 million workers versus 10.2 million pensioners in 2025 represents a near-collapse of the worker-to-dependent ratio, compounded by ongoing emigration of working-age adults. This structural imbalance makes retaining every available worker—especially skilled professionals—a fiscal and social security imperative, not merely a workforce planning preference.

3R: Retain imperative framed in fiscal terms: the pension system's solvency depends directly on retaining and growing the active worker base; makes the case for aggressive wage, housing, and social benefit reforms to stem emigration.

KSE INSTITUTE

IOM Facts and Figures 2024: Migration's Structural Role in Ukrainian Society

The IOM Ukraine Facts and Figures document contextualizes wartime displacement within Ukraine's long tradition of labor emigration, noting that migration has historically engaged a large proportion of the population in earning income abroad. This pre-existing emigration culture amplifies the risk that wartime displacement becomes permanent, making retention strategies more urgent.

3R: Provides structural context for Retain pillar: Ukraine's emigration-prone labor culture means wartime push factors combine with existing pull factors abroad, requiring retention policies that compete with established migration networks.

IOM UKRAINE

GLOBAL CONTEXT

IOM DTM Infosheet: Comprehensive Analytics Dashboard for Ukraine Displacement

The IOM DTM Data and Analytics Infosheet serves as the central hub for Ukraine displacement data, aggregating returns, displacement, and population movement data across all rounds including the latest Round 23 (May 2026). It provides the evidentiary foundation for all three 3R pillars by mapping where people are, where they came from, and what conditions they face.

3R: Essential monitoring infrastructure for all 3R strategy implementation; enables evidence-based targeting, progress tracking, and adaptive management of return, recruitment, and retention interventions.

IOM DTM
